



Lost roar: When the FIFA World Cup was first conducted in the United States in 1994, Nigeria and Italy had some of the loudest fans, with the former reaching the round of 16, and the latter making the final. AFP

The following month, just two days before the World Cup African playoff semifinal against Gabon, the entire squad downed tools due to unresolved wage issues. Though the matter was eventually resolved — and Nigeria dragged itself past the finish line with a 4-1 extra-time win — the cracks were clear.

Then came the revolving door of head coaches: José Peseiro, Finidi George, Augustine Eguavoen and Eric Chelle — four men in two years.

Chelle remained in charge for the final stages of qualification, where Nigeria lost on penalties to the Democratic Republic of Congo, with the coach blaming voodoo for the exit. Talk about analysis.

Beyond the quagmire of administration, the harshest blow came from the treatment table — Victor Osimhen's injury ruled him out of several matches. The former Napoli forward even fell out of favour with George, who claimed Osimhen was faking his injury, before missing clashes against South Africa and Benin.

The result: three matches, no

wins. Nigeria drew twice with South Africa and lost to Benin. Without Osimhen, it earned only four points from a possible 15.

His injury in the playoff final against DR Congo forced an early substitution, and Ademola Lookman followed 10 minutes later — leaving Nigeria to play most of the match without two of its most important strikers.

DR Congo, on the other hand, was a study in stability.

After failing to qualify for Qatar 2022, it offered a second roll of the dice to Sébastien Desabre as coach — and he repaid that faith by guiding the team to the World Cup after 52 years, beating Cameroon and Nigeria.

When the FIFA World Cup was first conducted in the United States in 1994, Nigeria and Italy had some of the loudest fans, with the former reaching the round of 16, and the latter making the final.

This time around, it will be their silence that rings loudest — a reminder that in football, failure is rarely accidental.



Other major teams that missed the cut

No encore for Sánchez

Chile, which reached the round of 16 in each of its last three World Cup appearances, missed out on the 2026 edition — the third consecutive time it has fallen short — potentially ending Alexis Sánchez's chances of playing in the tournament again.

Curtain call cut short

Poland legend Robert Lewandowski broke down after a 2-3 loss to Sweden in the playoffs saw his team miss out on a World Cup spot for the first time since 2014, denying the star striker a final dance on the biggest stage.

Mbeumo misses the party

Bryan Mbeumo will miss his first chance to play in a World Cup as his team, Cameroon — the 1990 quarterfinalist — failed to qualify for the expanded 48-team 2026 edition, set to be played in the USA, Mexico and Canada.